some interview subjects requested anonymity. Because of the personal and professional risks involved for a number of those who spoke with me, I have approached identification of my sources with great caution. Anonymous sourcing is widely recognized as necessary when researching clandestine militant groups. It is also undeniably contentious because it removes accountability for both the source and, to a degree, the author. This is magnified by the fact that some interview subjects had a stake in skewing facts and analysis. To mitigate this I attempted to solicit enough information from different sources to redress the bias of any one party. In addition to field research, I also relied heavily on primary source material in the form of statements by the group and legal documents. This is supplemented with media accounts and the existing literature. I have tried to support anonymous assessments with those from onthe-record sources or written accounts, and in general endeavored to pursue a policy of dual sourcing wherever possible. All direct quotations appear as found in the original source material; [sic] is not used, though in some instances language has been inserted in brackets for clarification.

In gathering material for this book, it became clear that Lashkar is often misunderstood, owing partially to the fact that it wishes to be. Where myths exist, I try to debunk them using facts. However, ambiguity still surrounds many of the group's activities. When this is the case I make clear that uncertainty exists. I also attempt to outline competing claims, to identify clues or trends that might point the way forward and to suggest possible explanations as well as the alternative consequences different scenarios could create. Although this opens the door to possible errors of fact or analysis, this is a risk that accompanies any empirical work about clandestine phenomena. I am confident the material gathered is extensive enough to chart the significant trends in Lashkar's evolution, but caveat lector: the group's story continues to unfold and with it comes additional data about the current state of play. It is inevitable that by the time this book is in print more will be known about Lashkar. The best this book can hope to do is to serve as a foundation for future analysis and to provide a baseline for critical debate.